

‘Polo not a sport for privileged few; it is for everyone’ – Lt. Col. Vishal Chauhan and Col. Garcha



A thought-provoking session titled ‘The Legacy of Polo’ took place at Poornima University during the *Sportstar Sports Conclave - Focus Rajasthan*. The discussion featured two polo stalwarts: Col. K.S. Garcha, former India polo captain, and Lt. Col. Vishal Chauhan, former India polo player, who shared their insights on the sport’s cultural significance and its future in India. The session was moderated by Sportstar’s senior sub-editor, Lavanya L.

For Chauhan, polo’s allure began at the army academy, where he first picked up the polo stick. He recalled how his early exposure to horses, thanks to his father’s military career, sparked an interest in equestrian sports, but it was polo that truly captivated him. “When I sat on the horse and picked up the stick, I didn’t want to play any other sport — it was addictive,” Chauhan said. He stressed the profound bond between the rider and horses, describing it as “another being, an animal that has its own soul.”

Polo’s roots trace back to Central Asia, with Genghis Khan’s legendary matches, and it was revived in 19th-century India by British officer Robert Stewart. The sport gained global recognition as an elite pastime among royalty. In post-1947 India, the army preserved polo’s legacy, and today, it thrives in nearly 100 countries.

Chauhan also highlighted polo’s indigenous origins in Manipur, where the sport is still played in its original

Col. K. S. Garcha and Lt. Col. Vishal Chauhan weigh in during a panel discussion moderated by Sportstar’s senior sub-editor, Lavanya Lakshmi Narayanan. R. V. MOORTHY

form. “Polo is indigenous to India; it originated in Manipur, and we still play the original version in Ladakh and Manipur, where the rules are different,” he said. He noted how polo is woven into Rajasthan’s folklore, adding to its cultural significance.

Despite its rich history, polo in India faces a stigma, often seen as elitist. “Unfortunately, polo today is at its lowest ebb. It is a heritage sport, and it is important for us to keep it alive. We should ask the government to provide support and recognition for the sport, ensuring that it continues to thrive for future generations,” Garcha said. He also highlighted the potential for expanding polo in Rajasthan, particularly in cities like Jaipur and Jodhpur, but noted the need for investment and patronage. “India is one of the cheapest places to play polo, with army clubs offering affordable horse rentals,” Garcha said. “However, we need patrons to support the sport.”

Both experts agreed that polo could flourish in India with stronger investment, government backing, and a shift in public perception. With the right support, polo can once again become a cherished part of India’s sporting landscape.